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INTERVIEW

« Being an all-rounder should be encouraged, not sidelined »

MARCUS STOINIS

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Marcus Stoinis, one of the game's top all-rounders, isn't just known for his skills on the field — he's also unafraid to speak his mind. A month after announcing his retirement from ODI cricket, the 35-year-old has shifted his focus entirely to T20s. As a member of Punjab Kings in this IPL season, he is determined to help the franchise secure its first title.

Excited to reunite with Ricky Ponting and Shreyas Iyer, Stoinis also backs the BCCI's decision to introduce a second new ball in the second innings of night games, calling it a 'smart move.'

In a conversation with *Sportstar*, he reflects on stepping away from ODIs and shares his thoughts on why he isn't a fan of the IPL's Impact Player rule.

You were one of the major buys for Punjab Kings in the auction. As a new season begins, what are you looking forward to?

We are here to win. It's a new cycle, and there have been plenty of changes across the competition, with many teams reshuffling their squads.

This is a new franchise for me — although I was part of the team back in 2016 when it was known as Kings XI Punjab. It's a franchise that hasn't tasted success yet, but we believe we

have a strong squad on paper. Our aim is to build something meaningful over the next three years and establish sustained success for the team.

You worked closely with Ponting and Shreyas at Delhi Capitals. Now that they are leading Punjab Kings, how much of an advantage is that for you?

It's definitely an advantage for me, but I also believe it's no coincidence — it's by design from the big guy, Rick (Ponting). He's a big fan of Shreyas and has worked closely with him for years.

We all spent time together at Delhi Capitals, and I was with Shreyas in my first IPL season as well. I've also worked with Rick for a long time in Australia.

The fact that many of us have shared that experience is a big plus for the team. But in a long tournament like the IPL, getting off to a strong start is crucial.

Your retirement from ODI cricket just before the Champions Trophy came as a surprise. Was it a hasty decision?

From the outside, it may have seemed last-minute, but it was something I had discussed with our Australian coach, Andrew McDonald, for a while. With the next ODI World Cup [in 2027] still some way off, I felt

it was the right time for new players to step in.

A hamstring niggle during the SA20 may have sped up the decision, especially with the IPL following soon after. T20 cricket suits my skill set and aligns with how I want to manage my career for longevity.

I've spent years balancing T20s for Australia, the franchise circuit, and one-day cricket. At this stage, my focus is on playing as long as possible at the highest level — potentially into my 40s, like Faf du Plessis. That excites me.

Ultimately, the decision was about extending my career and playing in the best competitions, and it was made in collaboration with Andrew, as all my major decisions are.

With several senior players missing the Champions Trophy, do you think Australia lacked experience in crunch moments?

Of course, but the only way to gain experience is by being in those situations. It was an exciting opportunity for others to step up and handle the pressure.

While some players were certainly missed, that's the beauty of cricket. Look at India — young players are stepping up in every series, and different guys are making an impact in almost every game. That's how depth is built.

But am I ready to let that happen